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STARTUPS



Golden Dome may not be
the golden ticket Silicon
Valley is hoping for



Golden Dome, the Trump administration's gambit to build a next-generation missile defense system, has startups and longstanding defense contractors preparing to duke it out for a piece of a \$151 billion multi-year contract.

The process to qualify for the \$151 billion contract vehicle, essentially an umbrella program, is stacked against most startups — not because of their tech. Instead, smaller companies may be thwarted by a multi-layered, expensive bureaucratic process used to ensure a company can meet security and other compliance requirements.

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Ultimately, Golden Dome may not be the zero-sum battle of emerging tech versus incumbents. The startups that do breakthrough will be those that are able to convince the biggest defense contractors to take them on as subcontractors.

The Pentagon's Missile Defense Agency released last week [a draft solicitation](#) for a \$151 billion, multi-award contract, the prelude to the government's forthcoming defense tech buying spree.

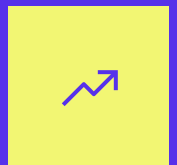
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The 10-year contract, called SHIELD, or Scalable Homeland Innovative Enterprise Layered Defense, acts as an umbrella that will be used to buy technology for the Golden Dome system. That program, which the White House likened to Israel's Iron Dome, will encompass systems that span space, land, and sea to protect the continental United States against a variety of missile threats.

In order to build out this system, the government will be looking to purchase a range of cutting-edge technology, like space-based interceptors, ground-based radars, and terrestrial and sea-based systems capable of taking out an enemy missile in flight. The first hurdle for companies hoping to win one of the contracts is to qualify for the umbrella program, or vehicle.

Getting onto the \$151 billion vehicle doesn't guarantee federal dollars; instead, companies will compete for contracting work on individual task orders. The final request for proposals will be released sometime in the fourth quarter of this year, though [that hasn't stopped companies from already starting their lobbying efforts.](#)

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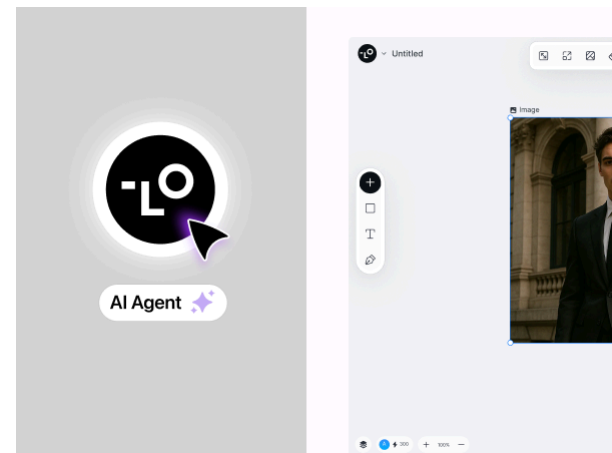
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Bryce Dabbs, CEO of consulting firm Approach Venture, told TechCrunch that he estimates between 5% and 10% of the pot could realistically go to non-traditional vendors — not by startups competing as a prime contractor, but rather through “teaming and subcontracting arrangements,” he said, noting that not all startups are equal. For instance, SpaceX and Anduril, while backed by venture capital, are already at the scale of small primes, and the opportunity for smaller startups will likely look considerably different.

A startup with a compelling technology would need to collaborate with a defense prime, like Northrop Grumman or Lockheed, to provide a capability that the prime doesn’t currently offer in-house.

That’s because many early-stage companies lack facility clearances, personnel, IT security, or other requirements to perform highly classified government work — and the pre-solicitation warned that these barriers to entry will be in place for would-be suppliers.

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Venture-backed companies like Anduril and SpaceX will be able to meet these security and compliance requirements, but everyone else will likely need to sub under a prime in order to compete.

Dabbs said his firm is seeing more early-stage founders reference Golden Dome in their decks, and that the program is frequently referenced when

VCs do diligence on startups Approach supports. But the investors “may not fully understand how government procurement or larger contracts work,” he said.

Meanwhile, more mature and cash-rich startups like SpaceX and Anduril are better poised to compete with the legacy defense contractors, such as RTX (formerly Raytheon), Lockheed Martin, Boeing, and L3Harris.

[Reuters reported](#) earlier this year that a team composed of SpaceX, Palantir, and Anduril has already started meeting with federal officials. Lockheed, meanwhile, launched a “Golden Dome for America” page on its website highlighting how it might contribute to the effort.

FAR, not fair

William Greenwalt, senior fellow at American Enterprise Institute and former deputy undersecretary of defense industrial policy at the DOD, was less optimistic. “I am not overwhelmed by the prospects for non-trationals to gain anything at all from this,” he said.

That’s because of the structure of the contract, which is being run under the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) and the Competition in Contracting Act (CICA).

While FAR requires “full and open competition,” the pathway’s high compliance standards implicitly keep newcomers out. Instead, Greenwalt said the program should be done as an Other Transaction Authority (OTA), which gives the DOD more flexibility to work with non-traditional vendors and fund prototypes with follow-on production opportunities.

“A CICA IDIQ contract is about the dumbest way to do this if you want innovation, as it will preclude non-trationals from bidding. This should be done as an OTA — plain and simple,” he said.

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Trump appointed General Michael Guetlein, second in command of the U.S. Space Force, to spearhead the initiative. He will be in charge of finalizing the program’s final architecture, which the White House wants to be in place in just three short years. That timeline favors technologies that are ready to be deployed now, not still being worked out in R&D labs.

“Golden Dome is a bold and aggressive approach to hurry up and protect the homeland from our adversaries,” he said in May.

Topics: [defense tech](#) [Startups](#)



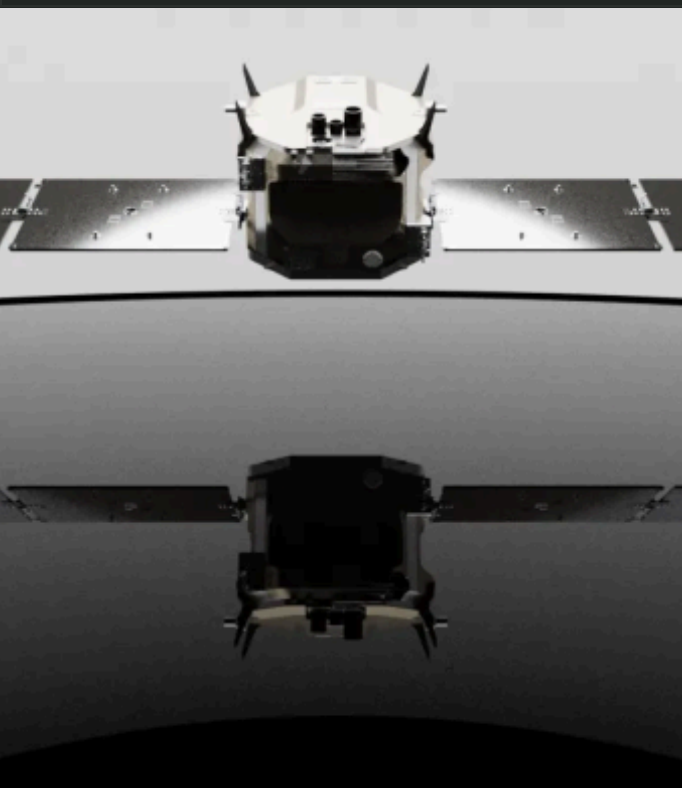
Aria Alamalhodaie

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Aria Alamalhodaie covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the...

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Defense startup True Anomaly lays off around 25%, cancels summer internship

Aria Alamalhodaei — 4:16 PM PDT · April 25, 2024

Space and defense startup [True Anomaly](#) has laid off around 25% of its workforce and canceled its summer internship program, TechCrunch has learned.

“With our rapid growth over the past two years, we looked at every aspect of our company to make sure we are laser focused on our goals and best positioned to execute,” a company spokesperson said. “We identified the duplication of roles and functions across the company, and as such, reduced our headcount. This won’t impact our ability to execute on our contracts with customers

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or on our mission to bring security and sustainability to the space domain.”

While TechCrunch could not confirm the total headcount prior to these layoffs, True Anomaly had over 100 employees as of December 2023, it told the [Denver Business Journal](#). Nearly 30 people were cut from the workforce, [according to a post on LinkedIn](#) from one of the people let go.

Employees started posting on LinkedIn about the layoffs on April 24; according to those messages, people impacted worked in sales, business development and recruiting. At least some interns were abruptly told the summer internship program was canceled last Friday, on April 19, as well. The internship was set to start on June 1.

The Centennial, Colorado-based startup [closed a \\$100 million financing round](#) last December; at the time, executives said staff had swelled to 107 employees. Earlier this month, True Anomaly CEO Even Rogers told TechCrunch [during an interview on the company’s first mission](#) that the company was “well-capitalized.”

True Anomaly hopes to modernize space defense with its Jackal spacecraft and Mosaic software platform for command and control operations. The startup envisions using Jackals on orbit to approach, image and gather intelligence on other objects in orbit.

True Anomaly launched that first mission, called Mission X, on March 4, though it ended early after the company failed to establish reliable communications with the two spacecraft that were deployed in orbit. The anomaly is hardly slowing them down, however. The startup is pushing to launch at least twice more in the next 12 months, aiming for another launch in October, one person told TechCrunch.

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The person was offered an internship, and spoke to TechCrunch on condition of anonymity, saying that a technical recruiter suggested that the internship program had been canceled because the company didn't have the human bandwidth to organize and supervise an intern project. The team is also starting work on [the \\$30 million responsive space contract](#) that the company was awarded earlier this month, the person said.

Topics: [defense tech](#) [Exclusive](#) [Layoffs](#) [Space](#)

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Aria Alamalhodaie

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Aria Alamalhodaei covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the...

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Anduril raises \$1.5B at a \$14B valuation

Aria Alamalhodaei — 9:01 PM PDT · August 7, 2024

Defense tech startup Anduril has closed what will almost certainly end up being one of the largest funding rounds of the year: a \$1.5 billion deal that values the company at \$14 billion.

Anduril has ambitions of becoming the next great American defense contractor, joining a class of

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companies that has shrunk to just five major firms: Lockheed Martin, RTX, Northrop Grumman, Boeing, and General Dynamics. These companies pull in billions in revenue from business with the U.S. Department of Defense, and their stranglehold on defense production is nearly absolute.

But the Palmer Luckey-founded defense startup is looking to become a serious rival to these long-standing kingpins, and its recent wins have started to draw notice. Earlier this year, the company beat out Lockheed, Northrop and Boeing [in a program to develop and test small unmanned fighter jet prototypes](#). Anduril is also betting that it can have an edge in contracts simply by moving faster than its competitors: bringing a Silicon Valley mentality to defense production, which moves notoriously slowly.

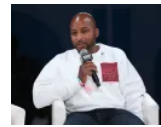
This latest round is a massive step up from Anduril's prior \$8.5 billion valuation set in December 2022. The company [reportedly told investors](#) that it had doubled revenue to around \$500 million last year, which would mean the current valuation is set at a 28x multiple. This is high by many standards for late-stage startups, but especially so for traditional defense companies: Lockheed Martin's revenue multiple is about 1.9x, based on its current valuation and last year's revenues, while Boeing's is 1.3x. Albeit those lower multiples are on revenues that are billions of dollars higher: Lockheed Martin [brought in \\$67.6 billion](#) in 2023, and Boeing's revenues were [nearly \\$78 billion](#) for 2023.

Anduril's new funding round was co-led by Founders Fund, which led Anduril's seed round in August 2017 and its Series A, and Sands Capital, which has participated in multiple IPOs since Visa's public offering in 2008. Founders Fund's participation is hardly a surprise, though, given the firm's long-standing bet on Anduril. The company's

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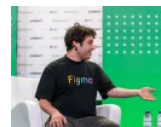
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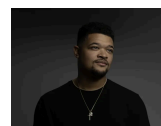
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co-founder and executive chairman, Trae Stephens, is also a Founders Fund partner. The round also saw new participation from some major institutional investors, like Fidelity Management & Research Company, and Baillie Gifford.

The company said in a statement that the new funding will help scale a new software-defined manufacturing platform called “Arsenal,” starting with the Arsenal-1 factory. That facility will increase Anduril’s production space by over 5 million square feet in order to manufacture “tens of thousands of autonomous military systems” per year, with a workforce of more than 1,500 people.

A separate manifesto outlines Anduril’s rationale for scaling manufacturing specifically. The company’s aim is to “hyper-scale” defense production and to produce defense systems at a scale that is not currently possible for exquisite military systems. But Anduril is not focused on making a few very expensive, exquisite systems; it’s focused on producing many times more cheaper products, which can be hyper-scaled with a rebooted factory. Arsenal is meant to be exactly that: an adaptable, replicable model that “scales indefinitely and makes it possible to rebuild the arsenal of democracy.”

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Not only that: Anduril says the centrality of software will also make the factory even more efficient over time, with the Arsenal Operating System facilitating faster, cheaper manufacturing. This will no doubt have an effect on the products themselves, which Anduril says will be developed to be less dependent upon highly-specialized labor. It can also help maximize the use of readily available components and make iterative changes to products quickly.

The 7-year-old company's success with the government and private investors has helped spur a boom of interest in defense tech, a sector that had been previously thought of as nearly uninvestable due to the long timelines in government contracting. However, it's unclear if Anduril's rising tide will truly lift all boats or if Anduril will be (as is so often the case in Silicon Valley) the exception, not the rule.

The story has been updated to reflect that Lockheed's 2023 revenue was \$67.6 billion.

Topics: [anduril](#) [defense tech](#) [fundraising](#) [Startups](#)



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